

“Christ, the Fair Glory of the Holy Angels”

Text: Rabanus Maurus, d. 856; John Athelstan Laurie Riley, 1906

Meter: 11.11.11.5

Suggested Tune: COELITES PLAUDANT

1. Christ, the fair glory of the holy angels,
ruler of all, and author of creation,
grant us, in mercy, grace to win by patience
joys everlasting.
2. Send forth Thine angel, Michael, from
Thy presence:
peacemaker blessed, may he hover o’er us,
hallow our dwellings, that for us Thy
children
all things may prosper.
3. Send forth Thine angel, Gabriel the
mighty;
on strong wings flying, may he come from
heaven,
drive from Thy temple Satan, the old
foeman;
succor our weakness.
4. Send forth Thine angel, Raphael the
healer:
through him with wholesome med’cines of
salvation
heal our backsliding, and in paths of
goodness
guide our steps daily.
5. May the blest Mother of our God and
savior,
may the celestial companies of angels,
may the assembly of the saints in heaven
help us to praise Thee.
6. Father almighty, Son, and Holy Spirit,
God ever blessed, grant us our petitions;
Thine be the glory from which all creation
ever ascendeth.

Reflection (Feast of Ss. Michael, Gabriel, and Raphael):

The original author of this Latin text, Rabanus Maurus, is best known for his Pentecost hymn, *Veni Creator Spiritus* (“Come, Holy Ghost, Creator Blest”). Although completely different in subject, is it interesting to note that this hymn shares its invocative nature. Just as the former repeatedly petitions the Holy Spirit to come and help us in our daily lives, this hymn repeatedly petitions Christ to send each of His angels to do the same.

Verse 2 begins this pattern, asking Christ to send His archangel Michael, whom the text describes as a peacemaker. This is an unusual description for him, since Michael is often portrayed as a warrior figure, the leader of the armies of angels, thrusting his weapon at Satan. All of these actions, however, aim at bringing peace. Peace is the tranquility of order, which Satan’s legions constantly disrupt. But, with Michael’s protection, peace may be restored so that all things may prosper.

Verse 3 requests Christ to present His archangel Gabriel, the one who flew down to Nazareth to announce Christ’s conception to Mary. This news dismantled the former order of creation: God became flesh and restored right worship through His death and resurrection. Thus, Satan is driven from the temple (the place of worship), and we are strengthened in our spiritual lives.

Verse 4 asks Christ to send His archangel Raphael. He is described as “the healer” since his name literally means “God has healed.” In the book of Tobit, Raphael heals Tobias and guides him along his journey to

his wife, Sarah. Likewise, the hymn petitions Raphael to heal and guide us.

The hymn ends with a cacophony of praise, with the aid of Mary, the angels, and all the company of heaven, to the Trinity. In verse 1, Christ is described as the glory of the angels and the author of creation. These descriptions are brought to fulfillment in the hymn's concluding doxology where all creation ascribes glory to God.